

Landing-page anatomy: hero, social proof, features, CTA

Week 6, Lecture 1, Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The five-section anatomy every converting SaaS landing page shares
- Hero layout patterns: centered, split, and full-bleed product shot
- The social proof band: logo strip rules and the testimonial alternative
- Feature triplets: three-column layout and copy discipline
- Bottom-of-page CTAs: how to close a page so visitors act

By the end of this lecture you can name every section on a landing page, say what objection it handles, and diagnose whether a given section is doing its job.

Part 1: the five-section anatomy

A landing page is a sequence of objection handlers

Every visitor arrives with a stack of questions. A converting page answers them in the right order.

- **Hero:** "What is this?"
- **Social proof band:** "Has anyone I trust used this?"
- **Features:** "How does it actually work?"
- **FAQ:** "What's the catch?"
- **Bottom CTA:** "I'm convinced. Now what?"

The order matters. A visitor who hasn't cleared "what is this?" will not be moved by your feature detail. The hero must do its job before any other section has leverage (Segall 2023).

The five sections, in order

Section	Height (desktop)	Primary job
Hero	480-800px	State outcome + invite action
Social proof band	80-120px	Transfer credibility
Features	320-480px	Explain the mechanism
FAQ	240-400px	Remove blockers
Bottom CTA	240-320px	Capture late converters

These proportions are starting points. Adjust by content, not by preference.

What a section "failing" looks like

A section fails when a visitor passes through it without clearing the objection it handles.

- Hero fails: visitor scrolls past without understanding what the product does
- Social proof fails: logos are unrecognizable, or no proof is present for a skeptical visitor
- Features fail: copy names capabilities instead of outcomes
- FAQ fails: it answers questions no visitor actually has
- Bottom CTA fails: it offers five options instead of one

The test: read each section and ask "what objection did this section just eliminate?"

Part 2: hero patterns

Three hero layout patterns

Each layout distributes visual weight differently. Choosing the right one depends on what evidence the visitor needs.

1. **Centered text**, headline on a centered axis, nothing competing
2. **Text-left / product-right split**, copy answers "what" and image answers "what does it look like" simultaneously
3. **Full-bleed product shot**, the UI is the strongest claim on the page

The wrong layout for your product is the one that makes the visitor's first question the wrong question.

Centered text: when to use it

The centered layout gives the headline maximum visual weight because nothing flanks it.

- Best for: products with a short, high-confidence headline that needs no visual reinforcement
- Best for: early-stage products where the UI is not yet polished
- Best for: products where the outcome is abstract (a service, a framework, a community)

Risk: a centered layout with a weak headline is just a centered weak headline. The layout amplifies the copy. Write the headline before you choose the layout.

Text-left / product-right split

The split layout answers two questions in one scan.

- Left column: copy answers "what is this and what does it do for me?"
- Right column: screenshot or UI answers "what will I actually see?"

Best for: B2B SaaS where the UI is a differentiation signal. The screenshot communicates "this is a real product" before the visitor reads a word of copy.

Rule: the product image must be at reduced opacity (80-85%) or contained with a drop shadow and border-radius. At 100% opacity it competes with the headline for first attention (Schoger, CSS Day 2019).

Full-bleed product shot

The UI fills the hero. Copy overlays or sits adjacent.

- Best for: design tools, dashboards, and consumer apps where visual quality is the primary selling point
- The UI must be genuinely impressive at screenshot scale
- The copy must have enough contrast against the background image to be immediately readable

Failure mode: full-bleed with a busy UI and insufficient text contrast. The visitor cannot read the headline because the product image is the same value as the copy.

Part 3: social proof band

The social proof band does one job

The band answers: "Has anyone I recognize used this?"

Design rules:

- Use grayscale logos, not color. Color logos compete. Grayscale logos are a quiet, unified row of credibility.
- Constrain logos by height (24-32px), not width. A wide wordmark and a square mark will read as equally weighted.
- Label the band: "Trusted by teams at" or "Used by builders at." Without a label, an unrecognized logo communicates nothing.
- Keep to 5-8 logos. More than 8 looks like padding. Fewer than 4 looks like you couldn't find examples.

When you don't have recognizable logos

A testimonial pull-quote outperforms a band of unknown logos.

The quote must describe a specific outcome:

"We cut sprint planning from four hours to forty minutes in the first week."

, Sarah Chen, Head of Engineering, Acme Corp

Not:

"This tool changed how our team works."

, Anonymous, Company

Specificity is what makes the quote credible. A vague testimonial is weaker than no testimonial because it signals that the company could not find a customer willing to name a specific result.

Part 4: feature triplets

Why three columns

Three items read as a complete set. Two read as a choice. Four or more read as a catalog.

A feature triplet has:

- An icon (24-32px, single icon set, outline style)
- A benefit heading (one line at your h4 or h5 scale)
- Body copy (two sentences maximum)

The three-column layout distributes across the full desktop width at equal visual weight.

Changing to four columns makes each column narrower than the body copy measure (45-75ch), which reduces readability.

Icon discipline

Common icon mistakes:

- Mixing icon sets. Lucide icons at 24px mixed with Phosphor icons at 20px creates stroke inconsistency the eye registers before the mind does.
- Using filled icons for feature sections. Filled icons are heavier and compete with the headings. Use outline icons.
- Picking literal icons. An icon of a calendar for "scheduling" is redundant. An icon that suggests the concept (a clock, a cycle arrow) is more flexible across translations.

One icon set, one size, outline style, across all three columns.

Heading copy: benefit, not capability

Capability heading	Benefit heading
Automated scheduling	Your week plans itself
Real-time collaboration	Ship together without merge conflicts
Analytics dashboard	Know what's working in 60 seconds

The visitor does not buy capabilities. They buy outcomes. A heading that names the outcome earns more attention than a heading that names the feature (Wathan & Schoger 2019).

Body copy discipline in the triplet

Two sentences per column. No more.

- Sentence 1: extends the heading with a specific claim
- Sentence 2: names the customer context or consequence

Example:

"Your week plans itself. The scheduler reads your calendar constraints and fills open blocks before you open the app on Monday morning."

Everything beyond sentence 2 belongs on a feature detail page or in documentation. A feature triplet is a tasting menu, not the full meal.

Part 5: bottom CTA

The bottom CTA is the closing argument

A visitor who scrolled the full page is either convinced or one sentence away from it. The bottom CTA should be the simplest element on the page.

What it contains:

1. A short outcome statement (not the hero headline repeated verbatim)
2. The same primary CTA button from the hero
3. Nothing else

What it should not contain: newsletter form, social links, secondary CTAs, related products. One button. The visitor knows what they want. Give them one way to get it.

Common bottom CTA failures

- **Repeated hero headline verbatim.** The visitor already read it. Use a compressed version or a different angle.
- **Five options.** A bottom CTA with a free trial button, a demo button, a contact form, and newsletter signup is a footer, not a CTA.
- **Underbuilt spacing.** The bottom CTA should have the same vertical padding as the hero. A hero of 600px height paired with a 120px bottom CTA section signals that the designer ran out of time.
- **Secondary visual weight.** The bottom CTA button must be the same style as the hero button: filled, primary accent, same padding. Do not reduce it to outline style just because it is at the bottom.

Vertical rhythm between sections

Consistent section spacing signals intention and makes the page read as an argument rather than a stack of unrelated boxes.

Between sections:	96px	(12 grid units)
Within a section:	64px	(8 grid units)
Heading to body:	24px	(3 grid units)
Between body paragraphs:	16px	(2 grid units)

Apply these values as a starting point, then adjust by eye. The goal: each section reads as clearly distinct from the one above and below it without feeling disconnected.

Take-aways

1. A landing page is a sequence of objection handlers. Each section eliminates one objection. Know which objection each section handles before you design it.
2. Hero layout choice depends on what evidence the visitor needs. Centered text amplifies the copy. Split layout answers copy and visual questions simultaneously.
3. Social proof band: grayscale logos at equal height, labeled, 5-8 max. No recognizable logos? Use one specific testimonial instead.
4. Feature triplets: one icon set, benefit headings not capability headings, two sentences of body copy per column. Three columns, not four.
5. Bottom CTA: one button, consistent styling with the hero button, vertical padding that matches the hero height.

"Design narrates every decision before the user reads a word. The question is whether you made those decisions or defaulted to them."

Ran Segall, Flux Academy, live landing-page session (2023)

What's next

- **This week, Lecture 2:** Designing the hero in depth: headline writing, subhead structure, CTA design, and imagery choice
- **This week, section:** Hero-section critique: tear down and rebuild three real SaaS heroes in Figma
- **Reading:** Week 6 reading at </c/design-for-builders-26au/readings/wk06>
- **HW3 (out this week):** Design a full landing page for your product in Figma

